

dry and bitter to sweet and creamy, depending on the brewing process and ingredients used. Porters are similar to stouts with their dark colour and roasted malt flavours, but tend to be lighter in body and less intense in flavour. Belgian-style ales are known for complex flavours, which can include fruity, spicy, and earthy notes. They are often brewed with unique yeast strains that impart distinctive characteristics to the beer.

While India continues to be a strong spirit (read whiskey) market, demand for beer is growing. Consider this: in FY25, sales rose to about 450 million cases from 405 million in FY24, as per the Brewers Association of India. A report by Market Research Future projects the market will grow from \$13.4 billion in 2024 to \$20.2 billion in 2032, at a compound annual rate of 5.2%.

There's headroom too. India ranks 13th in total beer consumption at around three billion litres. Yet, the per-capita sits near two litres versus the global average of close to 30.

Also, we love our strong beers (above 5% ABV), which account for nearly 85% sales. "Strong beer will continue to dominate but we are seeing an uptick in milder beers too," says Atul Kumar Singh, Co-founder of Lone Wolf beer from Onkara Beverages. "People are becoming more taste-conscious," he says. "They want a smooth beer, and they don't want a bad morning the next day." Lone Wolf sold about 130,000 cases in 2023, its launch year, finished fiscal 2024 with over 250,000 cases, and fiscal 2025 with around 300,000 cases. The company is projecting 25-30% growth

this year. The beer is currently available in Delhi, Chandigarh, Rajasthan, Goa, and Kerala. The company brews out of Punjab and Telangana and is currently bootstrapped, but outside investment is on the horizon.

At Fort City Brewing, a brewpub in Delhi that opened a couple of years ago, the tap list runs to eight at any given time. The co-founder, Gautham Gandhi, says lagers still lead sales, but one of his top movers is the saison, a Belgian farmhouse-style beer once brewed for field hands. "Lagers are a no-brainer," he says. "Simple, non-complex beer that continues to sell the most, followed by IPAs and then the saison." He credits cock-

